ENVIRONMENT | CLIMATE CHANGE

How to Save the World

The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change's latest report warns that stemming the slide towards ecological catastrophe would require far more ambitious action than has been seen so far

By Amarnath K. Menon



FREAK WEATHER Heavy rains in May triggered mudslides in Dima Hasao, Assam

MITIGATION MEASURES TO COMBAT climate change are a continuing and growing challenge. That is the poignant reminder from the latest and sixth instalment of an assessment report by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC). The report warns that global warming is set to reach 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels in the next two decades and only the most drastic cuts in carbon emissions will help prevent an ecological disaster. It states that 'climate-resilient development' is already a challenge and will be even more difficult if global warming exceeds 1.5°C.

The report shows Greenhouse Gas (GHG) emissions continue to rise, while plans to address climate change are not ambitious enough to limit warming to the 1.5°C threshold. Worse impacts are in store if GHG emissions are not halved in this decade and adaptation is not scaled up immediately. UN Secretary-General António Guterres calls the report "an atlas of human suffering and a damning indictment of failed climate leadership".

The report cautions that the window of opportunity for climate action is rapidly closing. The science is unequivocal: delayed action risks triggering impacts of climate change so catastrophic that the world will become unrecognisable. In their report, scientists from 65 countries find that the world should peak GHG emissions in the next three years to preserve prospects of meeting the 2015 Paris Agreement's target to limit global warming, among other temperature thresholds, to 1.5°C. In effect, with every fraction of a degree of global warming, climate change impacts will only intensify.

The other major challenge is to remove car-